also makes yoga eligible to procure international assistance for its promotion and preservation.

India's diplomatic initiative for yoga may not have had a direct geostrategic intent, but it strives to underline India's difference as a provider of practices related to its cultural and political experience, often in contrast with China. For Delhi's decision-makers, the culture of yoga seems to complement, and possibly even compensate for, India's material limitations, whether economic or military. Speaking at the 2017 yoga day celebrations, Modi reflected this thinking: "many countries which do not know our language, tradition, or culture, are now connecting to India through Yoga."[50]

Democracy as a political culture of pluralism

By emphasising the liberal nature of its political system, New Delhi has also positioned itself as a leading power when it comes to promoting a *political* culture of pluralism in Asia. In face of an authoritarian China, this could enhance India's capability to soft balance Beijing by offering an alternative path to sustainable development. Delhi's democratic soft power is particularly relevant as Beijing develops and deploys its capabilities to undermine democratic institutions in other countries and promote its authoritarian values. At the same time, in its regional periphery, India's successful political model endows the government with a distinct political soft power to assist neighbours in their democratisation processes and governance challenges. While India's geostrategic approach to democracy differs from the more interventionist West, and it also continues to comfortably relate to many non-democratic countries, Delhi has become more comfortable